

Eye on the **BALLOT**

It rained foundation stones and projects as the UPA Government rammed through scores of proposals in a pre-poll bonanza

| By Shafi Rahman |

It was a case of waiting till the cows come home. Four years ago, shortly after the tsunami wiped out lives and livelihoods in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, the UPA Government announced it would provide livestock to disaster victims. All these years, the ministers and the mandarins debated and argued over breed selection and the logistics of transporting the livestock from the mainland. Nothing ever came of it, until last week when the Government decided to give the victims cash instead of cows. After sleeping over key policy issues, the UPA Government engaged itself for much of the last fortnight in policy announcements as its ministers attended a staggering number of foundation stone-laying ceremonies and inaugurations. Welcome to the cattle fair of popular politics.

All this frenetic activity was telescoped in the run-up to the announcement of the poll schedule by the Election Commission which brought into effect the model code of conduct. The Cabinet meeting on February 23 explains the hurried strokes of the Manmohan Singh Government. Even senior ministers were taken by surprise when an unscheduled cabinet meeting was convened that day. The

day's meeting of the Union Cabinet and the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) saw approvals to 52 proposals, all in less than three hours. The proposals, some of them worth thousands of crores, were passed with discussion lasting less than four minutes. Three days later, another 20 wide-ranging and bountiful proposals were cleared.

The UPA threw bones at Central Government employees and pensioners, raising their dearness allowance by 6 per cent at an expense of another Rs 6,000 crore. Also queuing up for kudos are projects to upgrade highways in 33 Naxalite-affected districts at a cost of Rs 7,300 crore, a proposal for the upgradation of two highways connecting Jammu with Srinagar at a cost of Rs 8,436 crore, the interim trade policy with a Rs 325-crore export incentive package for the leather and textiles sectors to ensure job security for workers in the troubled sector. The CCEA imposed stock limits on sugar for four months to control prices.

The real sweetener came for Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav and Congress President Sonia Gandhi's constituency Rae Bareilly. The Cabinet allowed the Railways to build a rail coach factory in Rae Bareilly and an electric locomotive unit at



RAIL TRACKS IN THE VALLEY

UPA Chairperson Sonia Gandhi flags off the second phase of Jammu and Kashmir's railway line in Srinagar in February

NEW FACILITIES IN JIPMER

Union Health Minister Anbumani Ramadoss at a foundation stone laying ceremony at JIPMER, Puducherry in March



Madhepura—one of the two constituencies from where Lalu contested 2004 Loka Sabha polls. The CCEA also announced a Rs 3,070-crore revival package to clear the accumulated losses of all primary cooperative agriculture and rural development banks. Another *aam admi* abode, the small towns, will benefit as the Government allocated Rs 5,000 crore for the next four years for construction of one million affordable houses.

Many projects with a mysterious time lag also got a fresh lease of life. The Cabinet approved a scheme providing modern infrastructure for mechanical slaughter of animals and hygienic processing of meat, espe-